



Remote Access For Your PC

Access your PC anywhere, anytime...

Remote access is good fun for some and really necessary for others. It seems rather useless at first, but it can be useful for pretty much anyone. It's like carrying your PC around with you wherever you go. Imagine being able to access all your applications, your documents from anywhere — at work, on vacation, from abroad, or through your laptop or cell phone sitting in the living room. There are a few known issues that can stop you from connecting to your PC, but there are ways to bypass these. We will explain and go through how simple it is to solve some of these problems.

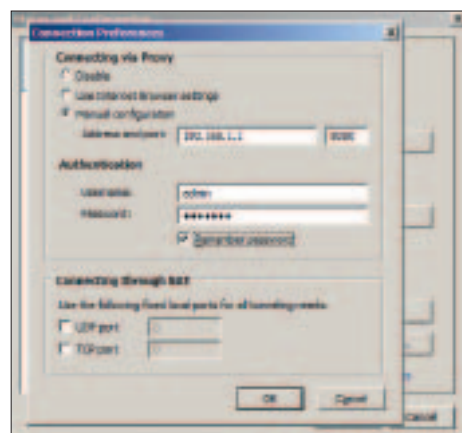
There are a few things to be aware of. Obviously, you need an Internet connection that stays on all the time when you're away from the computer. All the software we talk about should have open access to the Internet as much as possible. This basically means all the software firewalls on your computer should allow open access for them.

Making The Connection

Offices, large corporations and maybe a few internet providers block ports and provide only limited access to the Internet. Pretty much any work place today doesn't give every single employee a dedicated IP address. Even ISPs in the past have used a shared IP address and some even block incoming ports. If this means that a direct connection between two computers cannot be achieved, a third-party service needs to be used to bridge the gap.

Here's where Hamachi comes in. Hamachi is a virtual networking software that allows you to be part of a private network on the Internet, despite being behind firewalls and proxies. Hamachi has a free version and is available for download from www.hamachi.cc. Download and install the software. A virtual network adapter will be created alongside the physical network card on your computer.

Configuring Hamachi To Use A Proxy Server
Start Hamachi from the Start menu. If you are behind a proxy server, you need to enter the settings for the same in the Hamachi Preferences window. Click on the Configure Hamachi icon on the bottom right of the Hamachi window, and click on Preferences. In the Status view, click on the Detailed Configuration button under the Connection subheading. Click on Use Internet Browser settings if you want Hamachi to pick up the proxy configuration from your Internet browser. You can



Entering proxy settings into Hamachi

also manually enter the proxy address and port by clicking on the Manual Configuration button. Click OK when done. If you don't use a proxy to access the Internet, then there is no need to change the settings.

If you want more control and want an isolated VPN from Hamachi, there is a software called OpenVPN. The only downside is that it's highly complicated and requires a host computer running all the time with unrestricted access to the Internet.

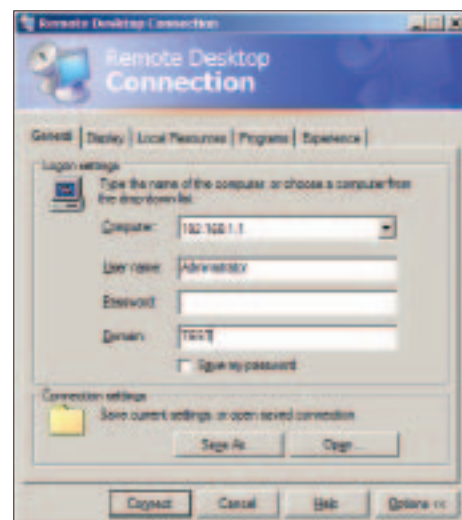
Connecting The Computers

Firstly, make sure all the PCs that you want to access have Hamachi installed. Next, you need need to create a network to which all the computers will connect to. Click on Create or join networks button and then on Create a new network. Give a unique name and password to the network. Remember this password. All the clients will use this to connect to the network. With the network set up, click on the Create or join networks button, and click Join an existing network. Enter the exact network name and password, and click Join. When you connect, you will see the other computers on the network. A flashing green light next to the computer indicates the PC is online.

Connect Using Windows Remote Desktop

There are plenty of remote desktop software for every platform. One that is available to everyone is the Remote Desktop Connection that comes pre-installed with every copy of Windows. First, Windows has to be set to accept remote desktop connections. Click on Start > Control Panel > System. Click on the Remote tab and click the checkbox "Allow users to connect remotely to this computer". Click on the Select Remote Users button. This selects the user accounts on Windows that can be accessed remotely. Click the Add button, enter the usernames and click OK.

Connecting to a remote desktop through Windows

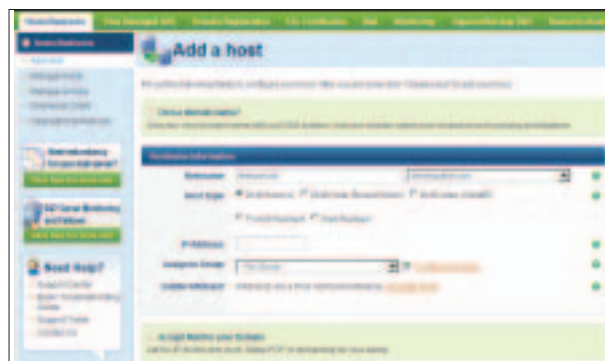


To access a remote PC, click on Start > All Programs > Accessories > Communications > Remote Desktop Connection. Enter the IP address of the remote PC on Hamachi. You can find this by double-clicking on the Hamachi icon in the system tray. If you have unrestricted access to the remote PC and you know the IP address, enter this IP. If you aren't sure of the IP, be sure to visit the site www.whatismyip.com from the PC you want to remotely connect to well in advance.

Setting up free domain hosting services

Services such as DynDNS (www.dyndns.com) or NO-IP (www.no-ip.com) provides free DNS services.

Instead of remembering IP addresses, you can remember a simple domain name. An example is remotetest.no-ip.com. An application on the client's computer updates the IP address to the domain name. You need to register with the site. Once you do so, login to your account on the NO-IP page. Click on Hosts/Redirects and click on Add Host. Enter a hostname and select a domain from the list of free domains. If you own other domains, you can select a group of which you want this new host to be a part of. Click Create Host when you done. With this done, all that's left is to do is download the client for your operating system and login using the same login information as the site. With the client running, the remote system can be accessed simply by using the domain name.

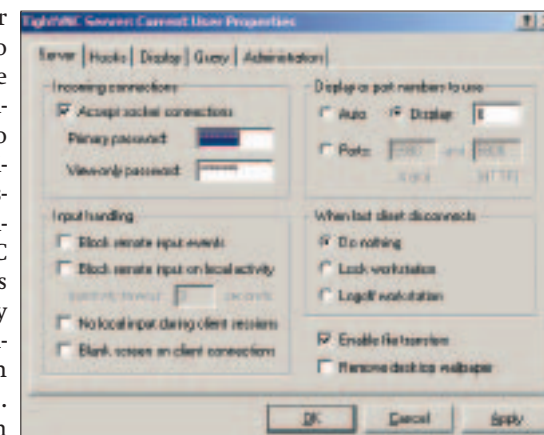


Creating a new DNS host

Connect using VNC

VNC is the other alternative to Windows Remote Desktop and is considered by many to be lighter, more optimised and customisable. The most commonly used VNC server-client is TightVNC. It is freely available for download from www.tightvnc.com. Another well known VNC solution is RealVNC (www.realvnc.com). Download and install TightVNC onto your PC.

On the PCs you want to remotely access, run the server application through the Start menu



Hosting a VNC server

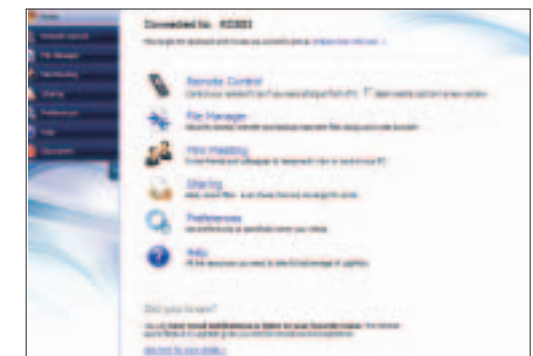
or run the WinVNC.exe executable from the TightVNC folder. Right-click on the icon in the system tray and click Properties. Enter a password that you want to use when you access the PC. Click OK. Advanced options for quality and refresh rate can be set as well. These can help bring down the amount of bandwidth consumption. You can also make TightVNC all the time run as a service by clicking on TightVNC > Administration > Install VNC Service. This way, you don't have to restart the VNC server every single time you reboot.

To connect to the VNC server, run the VNC client. Enter the IP address of the VNC server and click on Connect. VNC servers can also be connected to through a browser-based Java applet. To access the remote PC through a browser, open the following URL: http://YOUR_IP_ADDRESS:5900. Enter the password and you will have access.

Using LogMeIn

One of the simplest ways to access remote PCs is to use an online service called LogMeIn. This service allows users to access PCs behind firewalls using a browser. Register an account on LogMeIn (www.logmein.com). Choose to create an account for the LogMeIn Free scheme. Once you have the account set up, log into it from the site.

Click on the My Computers link and then on Add Computer. Select the Free product and click Continue. Proceed and download the installer. Install the application on your computer and enter the computer name during



LogMeIn is both simple and practical

the installation process. Once the installation is complete, click on the computer you want to connect to. Enter the username and password for the account. You can then use the web-based remote access utility to access the desktop or even access files. To access the desktop, click on Remote Control and File Manager to access the files.

Remote access has been implemented in much other software. uTorrent and Free Download Manager are the best examples of this and they come with built-in features for Web access. With a virtual network, it's easy to share data with others and access common folders. ■

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